Writing, Blogging, and Newsletters

12 ways to improve the written word

Adapted for blogs, articles, and email newsletters from engagement and deliverability research

Written content competes with the scroll and the inbox. Scannability, one-CTA discipline, and ruthless curation are what separate read from skimmed from deleted.

Opening and Structure

- **1. Write the headline or subject line first.** Specific and curiosity-honest beats clever or clickbaity; the promise sets the article's contract.
- **2. Hook the preview text.** The first sentence of an email shows in the inbox - write it as if the delete button is next to it.
- **3. Keep paragraphs to 2-3 sentences.** Subheadings, bullets, bold key phrases, and white space respect the reader's time.
- **4. Stay under 300-500 words for email.** Newsletters link out to depth; they don't reproduce it.

Substance and Voice

- **5. Use concrete details over generic claims.** Specific numbers, names, and moments are what readers remember and repeat.
- **6. Include failures with the wins.** Vulnerability builds trust; connect individual stories to universal experiences.
- **7. Bold every unclear term and link it.** If a reader might not know a concept, hyperlink the explanation inline.
- **8. Curate ruthlessly.** Deep insight on two topics beats surface coverage of ten.

Conversion and Cadence

- **9. One primary CTA per piece.** Make secondary actions hypertext, not buttons; the ask must fit the content's natural conclusion.
- **10. Segment your list.** By interest, engagement level, or journey stage - then tailor subject lines and intros to each group.
- **11. A/B test subject lines and placements.** Test one element at a time; you were sending something either way.
- **12. Draft ahead on a fixed schedule.** Never send just to hit the calendar; send only when you have something worth the reader's attention.

Sources

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